UNIT 5 · TOPIC 5.5

Protecting Applications

Assignment, Answer Key

Teacher answer key, 30 points total.

Practice Questions

5.5.a · Input validation and sanitization

1. Which validation strategy defines exactly what valid input looks like and rejects everything else, rather than trying to enumerate every bad pattern? (1 pt)

○ A. Denylist (blocklist)

● **B. Allowlist (whitelist)**

○ C. Output encoding

○ D. Canonicalization

Why: Allowlisting defines the known-good shape of input and rejects anything that doesn't match; it does not need to anticipate every attack variant.

2. Select ALL statements that correctly describe why client-side (JavaScript) validation is not a security control. (3 pts)

■ **A. A browser is entirely under the attacker's control, so JavaScript checks can be disabled or bypassed**

■ **B. An attacker can send a crafted request directly to the server with a tool like curl, skipping the browser entirely**

■ **C. Client-side validation must still be re-enforced on the server for any security-relevant check**

□ D. Client-side validation is cryptographically enforced and cannot be bypassed

Why: Client-side validation only improves UX; because the client is attacker-controlled, every security-relevant check must be re-verified server-side.

3. An application validates a raw, un-decoded path string before checking it for '../' sequences. Why is this a mistake? (1 pt)

○ A. Checking the raw string is fine, as long as the check is done on the server

○ B. The check should be done twice on the raw string to be safe

● **C. An attacker can URL-encode the traversal sequence (e.g. ..%2F) so it slips past the raw-string check, then gets decoded later, this is a canonicalization bypass**

○ D. Raw strings are always rejected by web servers before reaching the app

Why: If validation looks at the encoded form and the file system later sees the decoded form, the two disagree. ..%2F does not contain ../ until it is decoded, so it passes the check and then climbs directories. Decode and normalize (canonicalize) first, then validate the final form.

4. Name the security concept that transforms data at the point it is inserted into a new context (HTML, SQL, shell) so special characters are treated as literal data, not code. (1 pt)

Acceptable answers: output encoding; output escaping; encoding; escaping; context-specific encoding

Why: Output encoding/escaping is applied at each output context, since the correct transformation differs between HTML, SQL, shell, and JSON.

5. SQL injection, cross-site scripting (XSS), and command injection share what root cause? (1 pt)

○ A. They are all caused by weak passwords on the server

● **B. The application trusted that input was 'just data' when a downstream interpreter treated part of it as code or control syntax**

○ C. They all exploit unencrypted connections between client and server

○ D. They all happen because the server runs an outdated operating system

Why: In each case input crosses into an interpreter (the SQL engine, the browser's HTML parser, the operating-system shell) that reads some characters as instructions. The shared fix is the same idea: keep code and data separate (parameterized queries, output escaping, argument lists instead of shell strings).

5.5.b · Secure coding practices

6. Which practice eliminates SQL injection risk regardless of what input validation is or isn't done upstream? (1 pt)

● **A. Parameterized queries**

○ B. Escaping single quotes in user input

○ C. Using a web application firewall

○ D. Validating input against an allowlist

Why: A parameterized query sends the SQL statement and the values separately, so the database never parses user input as SQL, no matter what it contains. Escaping quotes, WAF rules and allowlists all help, but each can be bypassed or misapplied (encodings, odd characters, fields that must allow quotes).

7. Select ALL reasons secrets (API keys, passwords) should NOT be hardcoded in source code. (3 pts)

■ **A. They remain visible in version control history forever, even if later removed**

■ **B. Rotating a compromised secret requires a code change and redeployment**

□ C. They are automatically encrypted by the version control system

■ **D. Anyone with repository read access can see them**

Why: Hardcoded secrets persist in history, require a code change to rotate, and are visible to anyone with repo access; version control does not encrypt file contents.

8. An authentication check throws an unexpected exception. Secure coding says the application should: (1 pt)

○ A. Retry the check until it succeeds

○ B. Allow access but log a warning for review

○ C. Fall back to a simpler check, such as username only

● **D. Deny access by default (fail securely/fail closed)**

Why: If the code cannot confirm the user is allowed, the safe answer is no. Failing open (allowing on error) turns any crash into a bypass, and attackers deliberately trigger errors to find such paths. Logging is good, but only alongside denial.

9. Name the principle that says application processes and database connections should run with only the minimum access they need to function. (1 pt)

Acceptable answers: least privilege; principle of least privilege

Why: Least privilege applies to running code and service accounts, not just human user accounts.

10. Why is pinning and patching third-party dependency versions considered a secure-coding practice, not just a maintenance task? (1 pt)

● **A. A vulnerability in any dependency becomes a vulnerability in the whole application, so unpatched dependencies are unpatched attack surface**

○ B. Pinning versions makes the app download faster

○ C. Unpinned dependencies are blocked by most firewalls

○ D. Dependencies run in a sandbox, so only their bugs that crash the app matter

Why: Your app runs your dependencies' code with your app's permissions, so their bugs are your bugs (Log4Shell in 2021 hit thousands of apps through one logging library). Pinning means you know exactly which versions you ship, and patching means you update them when fixes appear. Dependencies are not sandboxed.

5.5.c · Application security testing (SAST/DAST)

11. Which testing approach reads an application's source code without executing it? (1 pt)

○ A. DAST

○ B. Fuzzing only

○ C. Penetration testing

● **D. SAST**

Why: SAST (static application security testing) parses source code directly and never runs the program.

12. Select ALL statements that correctly describe the tradeoffs between SAST and DAST. (3 pts)

■ **A. SAST can run before the code is even merged, giving very early feedback**

■ **B. DAST requires a running, reachable instance of the application**

■ **C. SAST tends to produce more false positives because it cannot always confirm attacker-controlled input reaches a flagged line**

□ D. DAST can see every code path in the application, including rarely-used admin features

Why: SAST runs early and over-flags because it lacks runtime context; DAST needs a live instance and only sees the paths it actually exercises, not every code path.

13. A dynamic scanner sends a crafted request to a live login form and observes that it can bypass authentication. What kind of finding is this? (1 pt)

○ A. SAST-only, since it's about code logic

● **B. DAST, since it required interacting with the running application**

○ C. Neither, since automated tools cannot find this

○ D. A compiler warning

Why: DAST tests the running application from the outside, exactly the way this scenario describes.

14. Name the kind of security testing that is performed by a skilled human who chains findings together and reasons about business logic flaws automated SAST/DAST tools cannot recognize. (1 pt)

Acceptable answers: penetration testing; pen testing; pentest; pentesting

Why: Penetration testing is human-driven and can reason about business logic in ways automated scanners cannot.

15. Why do mature CI/CD pipelines typically run BOTH SAST and DAST rather than picking just one? (1 pt)

○ A. SAST is required for compliance, while DAST is optional

○ B. DAST finds everything SAST finds, so SAST is only for speed

○ C. They find largely non-overlapping vulnerability classes, so together they give broader coverage

● **D. Running both lets each tool double-check the other's false positives**

Why: SAST reads code and catches issues like hardcoded secrets or unsafe functions early, even in paths that are hard to reach. DAST attacks the running app and catches what only appears at runtime: server misconfiguration, authentication flaws, how components interact. Each misses what the other sees.

Coding Assignments (Python 3)

5.5.a · Input validation and sanitization

3 pts · auto-graded on the site

Coding problem 5.5.a: Field validator (allowlist + injection detector)

Skill: Mitigate Risk · **Maps to:** 5.5.A · **Language:** Python 3 (pytest)

Problem

Build the server-side validation gate described in the lesson: given a batch of submitted form field values, classify each as SAFE or BLOCKED using **allowlist rules per field type** plus detection of known **injection meta-characters/keywords**, the same two checks a real input-validation layer runs before any value reaches a database query, HTML page, or shell.

Function contract

Implement `solve(submissions: list) -> list` in `starter.py` (see `interface.md` / `blackbox.yaml`).

Input

`submissions`: `list[dict]`, each `{"field": str, "type": str, "value": str}`. `type` is one of `"zip"`, `"email"`, `"quantity"`, `"username"`.

Output

`list[str]` of the `value`s that are BLOCKED, in the same order they appeared in the input.

Allowlist rules (per `type`)

- `zip`: exactly 5 digits.
- `email`: `local@domain.tld` shape.
- `quantity`: integer string 1-99.
- `username`: 3-20 letters/digits/underscore.

A value is also BLOCKED (even if it matches the allowlist shape) if it contains a known injection signature: `--`, `;`, `<script`, `UNION SELECT`, `OR 1=1`, `' OR '`, `DROP TABLE`, `../`, `%3B`, `%2F` (case-insensitive).

Examples

```
[{"field":"zip","type":"zip","value":"94107"}]                    ->  []
[{"field":"zip","type":"zip","value":"9410"}]                     ->  ["9410"]
[{"field":"u","type":"username","value":"admin'--"}]               ->  ["admin'--"]
```

Constraints

- Deterministic, offline, standard library only.
- Must pass all cases in `tests.py` (visible + hidden).

How to run

```
cd problem && python -m pytest tests.py -q
```

Reference solution:

```
import re
from typing import Dict, List

_ALLOW = {
    "zip": re.compile(r"^\d{5}$"),
    "email": re.compile(r"^[A-Za-z0-9._+-]+@[A-Za-z0-9-]+\.[A-Za-z0-9.-]+$"),
    "quantity": re.compile(r"^(?:[1-9][0-9]?)$"),
    "username": re.compile(r"^[A-Za-z0-9_]{3,20}$"),
}

_INJECTION = re.compile(
    r"(--|;|<script|</script|UNION\s+SELECT|OR\s+1\s*=\s*1|'\s*OR\s*'|\bDROP\s+TABLE\b|"
    r"\.\./|%3B|%2F)",
    re.IGNORECASE,
)


def solve(submissions: List[Dict[str, str]]) -> List[str]:
    blocked = []
    for sub in submissions:
        field_type = sub["type"]
        value = sub["value"]
        pattern = _ALLOW.get(field_type)
        allow_ok = bool(pattern and pattern.match(value))
        has_injection = bool(_INJECTION.search(value))
        if not allow_ok or has_injection:
            blocked.append(value)
    return blocked
```

5.5.b · Secure coding practices

3 pts · auto-graded on the site

Coding problem 5.5.b: Secure-coding configuration auditor

Skill: Mitigate Risk · **Maps to:** 5.5.A, 5.5.B · **Language:** Python 3 (pytest)

Problem

Build a lightweight policy-as-code auditor: given an application's configuration, flag every secure-coding practice it violates, exactly the checks a code reviewer or CI gate would run.

Function contract

Implement `solve(config: dict) -> list` in `starter.py` (see `interface.md` / `blackbox.yaml`).

Input

`config`: `dict` of settings. Any key may be missing.

Output

Sorted `list[str]` of violated rule names.

Rule set

| condition | violation | |---|---| | `debug_mode is True` | `"debug-mode-enabled"` | | `db_query_style == "concatenated"` | `"non-parameterized-query"` | | `secrets_in_code is True` | `"hardcoded-secret"` | | `error_verbosity == "verbose"` | `"verbose-error-messages"` | | `dependencies_pinned is False` |

`"unpinned-dependencies" | | runs_as == "root" | "excessive-privilege" | | code_review_required is False | "no-code-review" |`

Examples

```
{"debug_mode": True}                          ->  ["debug-mode-enabled"]
{"db_query_style": "parameterized"}           ->  []
{"runs_as": "root", "secrets_in_code": True} ->  ["excessive-privilege", "hardcoded-secret"]
```

Constraints

- Deterministic, offline, standard library only.
- A missing key never triggers a violation.
- Must pass all cases in `tests.py` (visible + hidden).

How to run

```
cd problem && python -m pytest tests.py -q
```

Reference solution:

```
from typing import Dict, List


def solve(config: Dict[str, object]) -> List[str]:
    violations = []

    if config.get("debug_mode") is True:
        violations.append("debug-mode-enabled")

    if config.get("db_query_style") == "concatenated":
        violations.append("non-parameterized-query")

    if config.get("secrets_in_code") is True:
        violations.append("hardcoded-secret")

    if config.get("error_verbosity") == "verbose":
        violations.append("verbose-error-messages")

    if config.get("dependencies_pinned") is False:
        violations.append("unpinned-dependencies")

    if config.get("runs_as") == "root":
        violations.append("excessive-privilege")

    if config.get("code_review_required") is False:
        violations.append("no-code-review")

    return sorted(violations)
```

5.5.c · Application security testing (SAST/DAST)

3 pts · auto-graded on the site

Coding problem 5.5.c: Static-analysis scanner (SAST)

Skill: Detect Attacks, Mitigate Risk · **Maps to:** 5.5.B, 5.5.C · **Language:** Python 3 (pytest)

Problem

Build a miniature SAST rule engine. Given the source lines of a file (as a list of strings, one per line, 1-indexed), scan each line for known dangerous patterns and return a list of findings, exactly what a real static-analysis tool's rule engine does before a human triages the results.

Detect these categories:

- `"sql-injection-risk"`: a SQL keyword (`SELECT`, `INSERT`, `UPDATE`, `DELETE`) combined with string concatenation (`+`) or an f-string/`.format(`/`%` on the same line (i.e., the query is being built dynamically instead of parameterized).
- `"eval-use"`: the line calls `eval(` or `exec(`.
- `"hardcoded-secret"`: the line assigns a literal string to a variable whose name contains `password`, `secret`, `api_key`, or `token` (case-insensitive), e.g. `password = "hunter2"`. An assignment that reads from an environment variable or config object (no literal string on the right-hand side) is NOT a finding.

Function contract

Implement `solve(lines: list) -> list` in `starter.py` (see `interface.md` / `blackbox.yaml`).

Input

- `lines`: `list[str]`, source code lines, in file order. Line numbers are 1-indexed (the first element of the list is line 1).

Output

A `list[dict]`, each `{"line": int, "category": str}`, **sorted by line number ascending**, then by category name ascending for findings on the same line. If a line matches more than one category, emit one finding per matching category. If no lines match, return `[]`.

Examples

```
lines = [
  'query = "SELECT * FROM users WHERE name = \'" + user_input + "\'"',
  'password = "hunter2"',
  'eval(user_expr)',
]
solve(lines) -> [
  {"line": 1, "category": "sql-injection-risk"},
  {"line": 2, "category": "hardcoded-secret"},
  {"line": 3, "category": "eval-use"},
]
```

```
lines = ['password = os.environ["DB_PASSWORD"]', 'db.query(stmt, params)']
solve(lines) -> []
```

Constraints

- Deterministic, offline, standard library only.
- Findings are sorted by `line`, then `category` (both ascending).
- Must pass all cases in `tests.py` (visible + hidden).

How to run

```
cd problem && python -m pytest tests.py -q
```

Reference solution:

```
import re
from typing import Dict, List

_SQL_KEYWORD = re.compile(r"\b(SELECT|INSERT|UPDATE|DELETE)\b", re.IGNORECASE)
_DYNAMIC_BUILD = re.compile(r"\+|f[\"']|\.format\(|%\s*[\"']|[\"']\s*%")
_EVAL_USE = re.compile(r"\b(eval|exec)\s*\(")
_SECRET_ASSIGN = re.compile(
    r"\b\w*(password|secret|api_key|token)\w*\s*=\s*[\"']", re.IGNORECASE
)


def solve(lines: List[str]) -> List[Dict[str, object]]:
    findings = []
    for i, line in enumerate(lines, start=1):
        cats = set()
        if _SQL_KEYWORD.search(line) and _DYNAMIC_BUILD.search(line):
            cats.add("sql-injection-risk")
        if _EVAL_USE.search(line):
            cats.add("eval-use")
        if _SECRET_ASSIGN.search(line):
            cats.add("hardcoded-secret")
        for cat in cats:
            findings.append({"line": i, "category": cat})
    findings.sort(key=lambda f: (f["line"], f["category"]))
    return findings
```